

Rapidshare fighting pirates

Fearing a sad and sudden raid on its service, Rapidshare is restricting download speeds—oh the irony!

Mozilla's own app store

To combat Google and Apple's dominance on the app market, Mozilla will open its own app store <http://bit.ly/wG4P3G>

Laptop Comparison

current state of laptops and where the segment is heading in the future with the steady emergence of ultrabooks.

General purpose laptops

Laptops that aren't ultrabooks (except the 11-inch Apple MacBook Air, which is a premium ultraportable) fall under this section. We were really looking forward to compare the machines we got. We are glad to report that we received representation from pretty much a laptop at every possible price segment that's available in the market, starting from a budget of ₹28,000 odd, which caters to the lower end of the market, all the way up to ₹85,000, the premium to high-end segment of the laptop market. Here's more on them.

Features

What we noticed here is that every manufacturer is caught in the rat race

of providing the maximum number of features on their laptops at any given price point. The result of this is that it's becoming increasingly difficult to clearly distinguish between two laptops based on features alone. Most new laptops sold today come with a second generation Intel Core processor, at least 2GB of RAM, 320GB hard drive, 14 or 15-inch screen, USB, HDMI, VGA, card reader slots, optical drive, six-cell battery, keyboard with chiclet-keys, Wi-Fi connectivity, and some version of Microsoft's Windows 7 operating system.



HP Pavilion dv6-6121tx



Sony VAIO C Series

ating system. The gulf between a budget laptop and a high-end, expensive laptop in terms of their features isn't as wide as it used to be, say, 3 or 4 years ago. Laptops have arrived at a minimum feature set, irrespective of its price, that's offered on each and every variety – like netbooks – they've reached a saturation point.

In this test, the top three laptops in terms of their features are the HP Pavilion dv6-6121tx,

Sony VAIO-C and Lenovo IdeaPad Y570. All three laptops come with a powerful combination of basic hardware components – the HP and Lenovo laptops sport a quad-core Core i7 processor, while the Sony VAIO C has a powerful dual-core Core i5 chip.

Both the HP and Sony machines come with 4GB of RAM, while the Lenovo laptop packs 6GB of RAM. All three laptops offer storage space above the average limit of 320GB: HP and Sony pack 500GB hard drives each, while

HOW WE TESTED

Not just for this comparison test alone, but this is how we generally test laptops for reviews conducted throughout the year in the magazine and online on the website.

PREPPING

We never benchmark a laptop's performance on its default partition and bundled operating system. We shrink the active partition to make room for another and install a standard 64-bit version of Windows 7 SP1 on all laptops. This is then followed by downloading drivers for all the components of the laptop and running Windows update. We do this to that ensure none of the pre-bundled

software has any effect on the laptop's performance score. After this step, we're ready to benchmark the laptops.

BENCHMARKING

We run a range of industry standard software benchmarks to measure a laptop's hardware capability and overall performance. We also measure performance with a bunch of subjective tests, consistent across all laptops – for e.g., watching a movie at a fixed volume and screen brightness to drain out a laptop's battery. Prepping and benchmarking take up the most amount of time while reviewing laptops – roughly more than half the overall time.

FEATURE LISTING

Here we take a look at all the features offered by a laptop, be it the range of connectivity options it provides or the operating system it comes bundled with, we also scrutinize it for anything it promises to deliver but doesn't. To put it more plainly, if a laptop claims it comes with 6 GB of RAM, we check whether it actually has 6 GB of RAM or not. We do this for all the laptops, against almost all the parameters that affect one's buying decision.

ERGONOMICS

While look and feel can be a matter of personal preference

to some extent, determining the best ergonomic design is a matter of scientific principles. In determining the Design & Usability score for every laptop, we take into account several factors like build quality, material used, hinges, keyboard deck, palmrest, touchpad, etc., and break it down exhaustively to arrive at a cumulative score for ergonomics, design and general usability aspects of the laptop.

After going through this process for each and every laptop, we arrive at a final score based on a formula with assigned weighted scores for performance, design, and features.